

Cisco Secure Workload - UK Cyber Essentials Plus Compliance Report

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Customer-Facing Compliance Report

Framework: UK NCSC Cyber Essentials Plus

Primary audience: UK organisations preparing for Cyber Essentials or Cyber Essentials Plus certification.

CSW positioning: Workload-level firewall evidence (control category 1), secure configuration baseline (category 2), patch / vulnerability prioritisation (category 3 - Security Update Management), and supporting evidence for technical verification (CE+ component).

Framework Version Note

References Cyber Essentials (CE) and Cyber Essentials Plus (CE+) as operated by IASME on behalf of NCSC. The five control categories are: Firewalls, Secure Configuration, Security Update Management, User Access Control, and Malware Protection. CE / CE+ requirements are updated periodically; validate against the current published requirements document.

CSW UI Navigation Note

Cisco does not yet publish framework-specific CSW UI navigation for this standard; framework-specific navigation is on the product roadmap. This report references CSW *capabilities* and the *evidence artifacts* they produce. The technical runbook (CSW-Cyber-Essentials-Technical-Runbook.md) in this folder contains the deeper engineering detail.

How to read the Coverage column

Every report in this set uses the same three coverage words. Coverage describes **what evidence CSW produces** for a topic — it never means the control is passed.

Direct — Secure Workload produces the primary evidence artifact for that topic (segmentation, policy, flow/process telemetry, inventory, vulnerability + reachability, forensic reconstruction). Direct is still evidence, not an attestation.

Supporting — Secure Workload contributes an input that feeds or complements another control, tool, or process (e.g. detection input only, reconciled against an external register, one log source among several).

Evidence Required — Secure Workload has no record for this topic. The customer supplies the contract, the analysis, or the HR / physical-security evidence from another control.

The Coverage ratings in the topic map below are machine-derived from each row's wording and are flagged for SE review before customer use.

Executive Summary

Cisco Secure Workload (CSW) supports a defined subset of this framework. The strongest customer story is not that CSW “certifies” compliance; it is that CSW turns workload communication and inventory into evidence that the customer, the customer’s compliance team, and the customer’s assessor can review. This report describes which framework topics CSW supports, which it does not, what evidence artifacts CSW produces, and how often the customer should collect them. CSW does **not** replace the customer’s governance, policy, or assessor judgement, and this report is **not** a control attestation.

Suggested CSW Scope Pattern

UK-Cyber-Essentials

- └ Internet-Facing-Systems
- └ Workload-Firewall-Scope
- └ Secure-Configuration-Baseline
- └ Patch-Evidence-Scope
- └ Verification-Sample

This scope pattern should be validated with the customer’s architecture, application owners, compliance team, and assessor before it is used for formal evidence.

In Scope for CSW Evidence

- Category 1 - Firewalls (workload-level allowlist and default-deny)
- Category 2 - Secure Configuration (workspace baseline)
- Category 3 - Security Update Management (CVE + reachability)
- Technical Verification (CE+) - workload sample selection support

Out of Scope (Must Be Evidenced by Other Controls / Tools / Processes)

- Category 4 - User Access Control (identity layer)
- Category 5 - Malware Protection (endpoint)
- Cyber Essentials questionnaire submission
- IASME certification body decisions

Framework Topic → CSW Capability Map

Framework topic	Coverage	CSW capability	Evidence artifact
Category 1 - Firewalls (workload layer)	Direct	Policy workspace + default-deny + workload-to-	Workspace snapshot showing firewall posture per workload

Framework topic	Coverage	CSW capability	Evidence artifact
		workload allowlist	
Category 2 - Secure Configuration	Direct	Workspace baseline + change log	Baseline policy workspace export + change-controlled exports
Category 3 - Security Update Management	Direct	Reachability-weighted CVE evidence	Prioritised remediation list with patch-due-date evidence
Technical Verification (CE+) sampling	Direct	Workload inventory + reach summary for sampled hosts	Sample-pack export for assessor

Evidence Collection Approach

The table below describes per-topic evidence collection - what to collect, the CSW source area, and a suggested cadence. The cadence should be tuned to the customer's audit cycle, regulatory cadence, and risk appetite.

Topic	What to collect	CSW source	Suggested cadence
Workload inventory	Workloads in CE / CE+ certification scope	Inventory + scope membership export	Monthly
Firewall posture per workload	Default-deny and allowlist evidence	Policy workspace export	Quarterly + after each change
Vulnerability + reachability	CVE list weighted by reach across CE scope	Vulnerability report scoped to UK-Cyber-Essentials	Monthly (CE expects 14-day patching for critical/high)
Verification sample pack	Per-workload posture for assessor-selected sample	Per-workload inventory, policy, and vulnerability extracts	Per certification cycle

POV / Workshop Approach

1. Confirm the framework version and assessment cycle with the customer's compliance team.
2. Select one business service, regulated boundary, or critical workload group to start with; do not attempt to instrument the entire estate in the POV.
3. Validate workload coverage and install sensors or configure supported connectors. Document the cannot-instrument register; this is itself evidence.
4. Apply labels for application, environment, owner, data class, criticality, compliance scope, and any framework-specific tags (e.g. tenant, prototype, isa_level, npi, cui, ephi).

5. Observe flows over a representative business window. Minimum two weeks; longer if the customer has month-end, quarterly, or seasonal cycles relevant to the scope.
6. Use ADM to generate a candidate policy. Review with the application owner. Run in Simulation mode for at least two weeks before any enforcement.
7. Package inventory, scope, flows, policy, exceptions, and known gaps as the evidence output. Cross-reference this report's evidence collection table with the customer's existing audit work-papers.

Boundaries and Complementary Controls

CSW does not replace the Cyber Essentials questionnaire submission, endpoint malware protection, user access control / identity governance, unsupported-software governance, the assessor's CE+ verification testing, or the IASME certification body decision.

Assessor / Auditor Caveat

CSW provides technical evidence inputs. The customer's qualified assessor, auditor, certifying body, or regulator determines compliance status. Validate all framework-topic mappings, control IDs, paragraph references, and section numbers in this report against the current official framework text. If the customer is being assessed against a version other than the one referenced in the framework version note above, revalidate before use.

Disclaimer

This report is for informational and planning purposes. It is not legal, regulatory, audit, or certification advice. Validate all mappings against the current official framework text, the customer's environment, and qualified compliance, legal, and audit professionals.